Two Years of Traces

The Criminal (in) Justice in LA Immersion is a multi-angle course. From 2024 to now, it has been two years that it has provided the opportunity for us to examine the Criminal Justice system and its history in LA through multiple perspectives, ranging from the LAPD museum, public defenders, Lawyers, and Journalists.

We started our first day with heavy introductory documentaries that reveal the racism from the 1992 Rodney King riots and the further conflict between different races, especially the Koreatown Community we visited during our last day. After hearing from judges and public defenders, visiting the LAPD museum, and going to court to hear about real cases and how fast the process moves when determining criminals' guilt, our schedule was packed with controversial but worth-debating topics.

Shifting from the seriousness of the history of the 1992 riots, our second week emphasized present-day advocacy in criminal justice, such as touring the Homeboys industry. The discussion with journalist Jessica Schulberg was truly immersive and surprising to me. As someone who loves to capture and write about news pieces I consider worth discussing, my expectations of journalism were once limited to short news articles. I often found it difficult to find or read long news stories that came as a cohesive, long-term series revealing social justice issues around race and gender.

With my interest and to get more insights into this time-demanding investigation process, I sat down with Jessica Schulberg again, a couple of weeks after the immersion ended. My curiosity stemmed from how she started covering criminal justice cases at The Huffington Post and the passion behind these time-consuming articles. Her journey started during the pandemic in March 2020, a period when communication and support to people were difficult to reach. With her self-initiated research and understanding of this circumstance, she identified that the prisoners in jails were extremely dangerous since they didn’t have the space for social distancing, therefore increasing the risk of being infected and not accessing the appropriate health care. During this period, the conditions in jails and prisons became an important part of the COVID-19 coverage, which she writes about. As years went by, her articles gradually transitioned to a focus on the injustice in the criminal system and the prison, especially when the case appears to be targeting the LGBTQ+ community and different racial groups. She also published relevant articles, including "The Struggle for Trans Care in Prison," and the case we examined in our immersion about the injustice suffered by Tremane Wood.

Another question that interested me the most was how the perspective of journalism that advocates for criminal justice affects how people perceive the case, or even further, the decision process.

“People assume that on death row, you deserve to be executed,” Jessica said to me after seeing a tremendous amount of unjust rulings and sentencing in the courts. Her journalistic work is new and eye-opening, helping people understand what is happening and the intricacy behind the outcomes we see.

Reconnecting from Jessica’s work back to our immersion program, her involvement started in 2024 when Melanie Berkey, who is our immersion teacher besides Zak Ramierz, emailed her. As a new experience for both this immersion and Jessica, she was impressed by this program and expressed to me that she had never seen such a comprehensive and practical course in the context of high school. Although the span of two weeks only enabled us to comprehend the surface of each perspective involved in a single struggle, this immersion truly met, or I have to say exceeded, my expectations of what I could learn from it.